

FROM CUSTOMER EXPECTATIONS TO CUSTOMER DELIGHT

A Kano Model–Based Customer-Centric Quality Improvement Framework

01 | CUSTOMER-CENTRIC QUALITY

Customer expectations in digital products and services do not remain static. Users evaluate quality through more than basic functionality; **reliability**, **ease of use**, **responsiveness** and **overall experience** can influence how they perceive value. In such an environment, customer feedback should not be viewed only as a mechanism for resolving complaints.

From a Quality Engineering perspective, customer feedback can become an input for understanding where quality expectations are being met, where performance can improve and where additional value may be created. This case study explores a structured approach in which customer signals are translated into quality priorities and carried into a **continuous improvement cycle**.

02 | UNDERSTANDING CUSTOMER EXPECTATIONS

Customer requirements can have very different effects on satisfaction. Some requirements are considered basic by users and their absence can create dissatisfaction. Other requirements influence satisfaction according to their level of performance, while certain features can create additional value when they go beyond normal expectations.

The Kano Model provides a useful way to distinguish between these different types of requirements. Combining Kano thinking with customer feedback, usage signals and emerging expectations allows quality priorities to be viewed from a customer perspective rather than treating every feedback item in the same way.

An important consideration is that customer expectations evolve. A feature that creates additional satisfaction today may become an expected part of the experience over time. This makes **periodic reassessment** important within a customer-centric quality system.

03 | CUSTOMER VOICE AND QUALITY SIGNALS

A customer-centric quality approach needs reliable inputs. Direct Voice of Customer can come from reviews, ratings, surveys, complaints and feature requests. These signals describe what customers are experiencing and what they expect to change.

Customer behaviour can provide another perspective. Usage patterns and recurring points of friction may reveal needs that are not always expressed directly. Emerging requests and changing preferences can also indicate where expectations are moving.

The proposed framework therefore considers customer feedback together with relevant usage signals and emerging expectations. The purpose is not to assume that one source represents the complete customer experience, but to bring different signals together before making **quality decisions**.

04 | KANO MODEL AS A QUALITY PERSPECTIVE

The Kano Model classifies customer requirements according to their relationship with satisfaction. **Must-Be** requirements represent basic expectations. Their presence may not create significant additional satisfaction, but their absence can lead to dissatisfaction. **Performance** requirements have a more direct relationship with satisfaction, where improvement in performance can increase customer satisfaction. **Attractive** requirements can provide additional value by exceeding what customers normally expect.

MUST-BE	PERFORMANCE	ATTRACTIVE
Basic expectation baseline. Absence causes severe dissatisfaction; presence is assumed.	Higher performance yields higher satisfaction proportionally across user segments.	Delighters creating unique value beyond normal expectations without prior demand.

For Quality Engineering, this classification provides more than a way to describe customer preferences. It can support prioritisation by helping distinguish between maintaining a basic quality level, improving existing performance and evaluating opportunities that may create additional customer value.

Kano categories should not be treated as permanently fixed. As customer expectations mature, an Attractive requirement may gradually become a Performance expectation and eventually approach the level of a Must-Be requirement. Periodic reassessment therefore becomes an important part of the **proposed approach**.

05 | PRIORITISING QUALITY IMPROVEMENT

Kano classification alone should not determine every improvement decision. A requirement may be important because of its customer impact, frequency of feedback or potential effect on perceived quality. Practical feasibility also needs to be considered before committing resources to an improvement.

The proposed approach therefore considers Kano category together with customer impact, feedback frequency, potential quality effect and implementation feasibility. Must-Be requirements can establish the quality baseline, Performance requirements can become priorities for continuous improvement, and Attractive requirements can be evaluated as **opportunities for additional customer value**.

This creates a more structured quality decision process instead of responding only to the loudest or most frequent individual complaint.

06 | VALIDATING CUSTOMER-CENTRIC IMPROVEMENT

An improvement should not be considered successful simply because a change has been implemented. Its effect needs to be evaluated through appropriate customer and quality indicators.

A before-and-after comparison can help determine whether customer satisfaction, complaint trends, relevant usage behaviour or other suitable quality indicators have changed following an improvement. Post-improvement customer feedback provides another opportunity to understand whether the original requirement has actually been addressed.

This validation step is important because it connects improvement activity with its intended **customer outcome**. It also provides evidence for deciding whether a change should be retained, modified or taken into another improvement cycle.

07 | DIFFERENT CUSTOMERS, DIFFERENT EXPECTATIONS

Different customer groups may value different aspects of a digital experience. An improvement that is highly valuable for one segment may not have the same importance for another, and in some situations a change intended to improve one experience may create unintended effects elsewhere.

Customer segmentation can therefore be considered when evaluating improvement priorities. Customer impact, quality impact, feasibility and potential unintended effects should be considered together rather than optimising one **customer metric** in isolation.

This perspective supports a more balanced approach to customer-centric quality, particularly where products serve diverse user groups with different expectations.

08 | CONTINUOUS REASSESSMENT AND STANDARDISATION

Customer-centric quality improvement should not end after implementation and validation. Customer feedback, usage signals and emerging expectations can continue to change, creating new requirements and changing the importance of existing ones.

Where an improvement demonstrates positive results, its learning can be captured and incorporated into standard practices where appropriate. The resulting experience can then become an input for future customer analysis and **Kano reassessment**.

This creates a continuous learning cycle in which customer insight informs quality priorities, improvement is validated through outcomes and proven learning is carried forward into subsequent improvement activities.

QUALITY METHODS APPLIED

Kano Model — Customer requirement classification

Voice of Customer (VoC) — Customer needs and feedback

Customer Segmentation — Understanding user group differences

Feedback Analysis — Identifying recurring customer signals

Pareto Analysis — Prioritising recurring quality concerns

PDCA — Structured continuous improvement

Before–After Validation — Evaluating improvement outcomes

Continuous Improvement — Sustaining the learning cycle

FINAL QUALITY INSIGHT

“Customer focus becomes quality improvement when customer signals are understood, prioritised, validated through outcomes and carried into the next improvement cycle.”

Independent professional research exercise developed independently as part of Jagriti Singh's #100DaysOfTQM learning series. This case study represents an independently proposed Quality Engineering approach and is not an official Google project, internal Google document, audit, endorsement or affiliation with Google. All concepts and perspectives are formulated purely from public quality engineering methodologies and independent professional knowledge.